▼ GLASSHOUSE



FREQUENT FLYER FILES

Prime Minister Narendra Modi has been quite the globetrotter this year, and now we've got the receipts, so to speak. In response to questions posed by TMC MP Derek O'Brien in the Rajya Sabha, it turned out that Rs 67.07 crore has been spent this year on the PM's visits to five countries: France, the US, Thailand, Sri Lanka and Saudi Arabia. Bills for nine more visits are still being tallied. Between 2021 and 2024, the grand total came to around Rs 295 crore, with the US topping the charts at Rs 74.44 crore. Publicity expenses abroad added another Rs 1 crore because a little dazzle never hurts. Expenses included delegations too, sometimes as large as 145 tagging along in 2024. Call it diplomacy with frequent flyer flair.

Illustrations by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

▼ POWER POINT

OUTAGE OUTRAGE

Uttar Pradesh energy minister **A.K. Sharma** is back in the spotlight—and not how his party would have wanted it. At a Moradabad event, a power outage struck just as the BJP leader was about to inaugurate a theatre. Sharma responded by suspending five senior officials on the spot. Soon after, in Sultanpur, residents confronted him over daily power cuts. He offered no answers, just folded his hands, chanted "Jai Shri Ram, Jai Bajrang Bali" and drove away. Now, he's under fire again for allegedly using a casteist slur during a departmental meeting while berating officials. From blackouts to backlash, Sharma's response to the power crisis is attracting more attention than any solution.

